Mark Scheme (Results)

History

Paper 3: Modern depth study

Option 31: Weimar and Nazi Germany, 1918-39

Mock Paper 3 (NotebookLM Prediction) - Teacher Copy

SECTION A

Answer ALL questions in this section.

1 Give two things you can infer from Source A about the situation in Germany in November 1918.

(4)

* **(i) What I can infer:** I can infer that the end of the First World War had caused complete social and economic collapse, leaving the population starving.

* *Details in the source that tell me this:* The source describes the German people as "broken, starving, and despairing".

* **(ii) What I can infer:** I can infer that the abdication of the Kaiser had created a dangerous power vacuum and a threat of communist revolution.

* *Details in the source that tell me this:* The source notes that "the Kaiser has fled, leaving no authority" and that "armed workers' and soldiers' councils are taking over".

2 **Explain why the German Revolution of 1918 occurred.** (12)

*You **may** use the following in your answer:*

- Military defeat / the blockade
- The Kiel Mutiny

*You **must** also use information of your own.*

The German Revolution of 1918, which swept away the autocratic Kaiserreich and led to the creation of the Weimar Republic, was caused by a combination of military failure, domestic starvation, and political collapse. The fundamental cause of the revolution was Germany's imminent military defeat in the First World War. By the summer of 1918, the German army's final offensive had failed, and the entry of the United States had tipped the military balance decisively in favor of the Allies. Knowing the war was lost, Germany's military commanders, Ludendorff and Hindenburg, advised the Kaiser to hand power to a civilian government to secure a more favorable peace. This sudden admission of defeat shocked the German public, who had been lied to by wartime propaganda, and shattered their faith in the imperial government's leadership.

Furthermore, this military exhaustion was worsened by severe starvation and suffering on the home front, caused by the British naval blockade. The blockade had cut off Germany's imports of food and fertilizer, resulting in catastrophic food shortages. By 1918, over 750,000 German civilians had died from starvation and related illnesses. The population was physically and mentally broken. Consequently, when the Spanish Flu epidemic struck, it swept through a weakened and despairing population, fueling deep-seated anger against the Kaiser and the ruling elites. This suffering convinced ordinary Germans that the imperial system was sacrificing their lives for a futile war, creating a highly volatile revolutionary climate.

This domestic anger exploded into open rebellion with the Kiel Mutiny in late October 1918. Realizing the war was lost, naval commanders in Kiel ordered a final, suicidal battle against the British navy to save the "honor" of the fleet. Refusing to participate in what they saw as a death sentence, the sailors mutinied. The mutiny spread rapidly across Germany's industrial ports and cities. Armed sailors and factory workers formed "workers' and soldiers' councils" to seize municipal buildings and factories, mimicking the Bolshevik Revolution in Russia. To prevent a complete communist takeover, moderate Social Democrats led by Friedrich Ebert demanded the Kaiser's abdication. On 9 November 1918, Kaiser Wilhelm II abdicated and fled to exile in Holland, and Philipp Scheidemann declared the new German Republic. Thus, the revolution was the direct result of a population driven to rebellion by military defeat, starvation, and a refusal to die for a collapsing imperial regime.

3 **Explain why the German economy collapsed into hyperinflation in 1923.** (12)

*You **may** use the following in your answer:*

- Reparations
- The French occupation of the Ruhr

*You **must** also use information of your own.*

The catastrophic hyperinflation crisis of 1923, which saw the German mark become completely worthless, was caused by the structural weaknesses of the Weimar economy, the burden of war reparations, and a disastrous policy of passive resistance. The long-term cause of the crisis lay in the war reparations demanded by the Allies under the Treaty of Versailles. In 1921, the reparations bill was fixed at the astronomical sum of £6.6 billion, to be paid in annual installments. Germany was already economically crippled by the cost of the war, and the loss of its rich coalfields in Alsace-Lorraine and Silesia severely reduced its industrial capacity to generate wealth. Bypassing regular taxation, the Weimar government began printing paper marks to buy foreign currency to pay the Allies, which immediately triggered a steady devaluation of the mark between 1921 and 1922.

The crisis reached a tipping point in January 1923 when Germany failed to deliver a planned payment of coal and telegraph poles. In response, French and Belgian troops invaded and occupied the Ruhr, Germany's industrial heartland, intending to confiscate coal and steel directly as reparations. The Weimar government, militarily powerless due to the Versailles restrictions, could not resist physically. Instead, the Chancellor called for "passive resistance," ordering the workers in the Ruhr to go on strike and refuse to cooperate with the occupying forces. This was a disaster for the German economy, as it instantly cut off the Ruhr's massive industrial output, which Germany relied on for tax revenue and exports.

To support the striking workers and their families, the government took the fatal step of printing vast amounts of paper money to pay their wages. Because there was no industrial production in the Ruhr to back up this newly printed money, the currency collapsed spectacularly. The supply of money far outstripped the supply of goods in the shops, leading to rapid, uncontrollable price rises. By late 1923, the price of a loaf of bread rose to over 200 billion marks, and workers had to be paid twice a day so they could buy food before prices doubled again. This hyperinflation was the direct consequence of a government printing money to pay for a strike it could not afford, while its primary source of industrial wealth was occupied by a foreign army.

SECTION B

For use with Section B, Answer ALL questions.

Source B: A photograph showing members of the League of German Maidens (BDM) practicing domestic skills in a specialized training center, 1937.



Source C: From a secret report by the Social Democratic Party in exile (SOPADE), 1938.

"We must report that enthusiasm for the Hitler Youth is declining rapidly. Now that membership has been made compulsory, the teenagers view the meetings as a boring chore rather than an exciting adventure. The boys are highly rebellious against the military drill and the constant marching in the mud. In this district, usually only a third of the group appears for roll-call. At evening meetings, it is a great event if 20 turn up out of 80, but usually there are only about 10 or 12. The youth leaders, who are barely older than the members, act with arrogance, which causes deep resentment. Many parents are secretly supporting their children's absenteeism to protect them from this mind-numbing militarism."

Interpretation 1: From Indoctrinating a Generation by Dr. Klaus Fischer, published in 1995.

"The Nazi regime was highly successful in achieving its primary aim of controlling and brainwashing the minds of the younger generation. By coordinating both the school curriculum and leisure time, the state successfully isolated children from traditional family and religious influences. The Hitler Youth and the BDM met strong emotional needs for community, adventure, and belonging among teenagers. The constant physical training, ideological lectures, and military drilling successfully produced a generation of fanatical, loyal supporters of Adolf Hitler. Even when the war broke out,

this indoctrination ensured that young Germans conformed and fought with unmatched fanaticism, proving that the Nazification of the youth was a complete success."

Interpretation 2: From Youth and Rebellion in the Third Reich by Dr. Arno Kitson, published in 2001.

"The Nazification of German youth was only a superficial success that masked growing boredom, resentment, and active rebellion. While the regime succeeded in forcing millions of teenagers into its youth organisations through compulsory membership laws in 1936, it failed to win their hearts and minds. As the 1930s progressed, the Hitler Youth became increasingly militarized, and the exciting camping trips were replaced by repetitive, grueling military drill. This led to massive absenteeism, passive non-conformity, and the rise of illegal, breakaway youth groups like the Edelweiss Pirates and the Swing Youth. These groups deliberately rejected Nazi discipline, proving that the regime's youth policies had failed to secure total control."

3(a) Answer:
Source B is highly useful for investigating the Nazi regime's ideological aims and policies for young women. The content shows how the BDM was used to enforce traditional gender roles, with girls practicing domestic skills like "preparing healthy meals" and caring for "baby dolls" to prepare them for motherhood. It is useful because it highlights the focus on the "Three Ks"—children, kitchen, and church. The provenance of the source—a photograph taken in 1937—is useful because it represents the official image the Nazi state wished to project. However, its utility is limited because as a staged, official photograph, it is a piece of propaganda designed to show perfect order, happy conformity, and submission to the *Führer*. It does not reveal the true feelings of the girls, but is highly useful for showing *how* the state used visual media to promote its domestic ideals for women.

Source C is extremely useful for investigating the reality of youth non-conformity and the failures of Nazi youth policies. The content reveals that enthusiasm was "declining rapidly" after membership was made compulsory in 1936, with high rates of absenteeism where "usually only a third of the group appears for roll-call". It is useful because it explains the causes of this rebellion: the "boring military drill," "marching in the mud," and the "arrogance" of the youth leaders. The provenance—a secret report by the Social Democratic Party in exile (SOPADE) in 1938—is highly useful because as a covert political intelligence report, it provides a realistic, uncensored counter-perspective to Nazi propaganda. While the SOPADE may have had a bias toward highlighting Nazi failures, the specific statistics and details regarding regional absenteeism make it a highly valuable source for understanding the limits of totalitarian control.

3(b) Answer:
The main difference is that Interpretation 1 argues that Nazi youth policies were highly successful in brainwashing and controlling the younger generation, creating a loyal, fanatical, and conformed population of Nazi supporters through the Hitler Youth and BDM.

On the other hand, Interpretation 2 argues that the Nazification of the youth was only a superficial success that ultimately failed to win their hearts and minds. It asserts that compulsory membership led to growing boredom and resentment, resulting in widespread absenteeism and the rise of active opposition groups like the Edelweiss Pirates.

3(c) Answer:
The interpretations differ because the historians have chosen to focus on different evidence and have given weight to different sources. The author of Interpretation 1 has given weight to official sources and photographs similar to Source B, which depict healthy, disciplined, and apparently happy BDM members conforming to their designated roles. This supports the view

that the youth were successfully indoctrinated.

In contrast, the author of Interpretation 2 has placed more weight on internal, critical accounts like Source C, which document the widespread boredom, low attendance figures, and growing resentment of teenagers toward the "military drill". This supports the view that the policies faced major resistance and failed to achieve complete Nazification.

3(d) Answer:
Interpretation 2 presents a highly convincing argument that the Nazification of German youth was a superficial success that masked deep-seated resentment and active non-conformity. To a very large extent, this interpretation is accurate. From my own knowledge, when the Nazis made membership of the Hitler Youth compulsory in 1936, the organization's character changed. The early, exciting elements of "comradeship" and "adventure" were systematically replaced by grueling, repetitive military drill designed to prepare boys for conscription and war. As Source C demonstrates, this rigid militarism alienated many teenagers, leading to massive levels of passive resistance, including chronic absenteeism where only a fraction of members turned up for roll-calls. For many, the meetings were viewed as a tedious chore rather than an ideological calling.

Furthermore, this alienation led to the rise of active, rebellious counter-cultures among the young, as highlighted in Interpretation 2. Working-class teenagers formed the Edelweiss Pirates, who rejected Nazi discipline. They grew their hair long, sang anti-Nazi songs, and went on independent hikes, often physically attacking Hitler Youth patrols. In the cities, middle-class youth formed the Swing Youth, who defied Nazi racial and cultural regulations by listening to banned American jazz and swing music. These active rebellions prove that the state's total monopoly on youth leisure had failed.

However, Interpretation 1 offers a vital counter-perspective by showing that for a vast portion of the youth, the indoctrination was highly successful. From my own knowledge, the Nazis completely controlled schools under Education Minister Bernhard Rust. Teachers were forced to join the Nazi Teachers' League, and the curriculum was entirely subverted to teach anti-Semitism and physical fitness. As Source B shows, BDM girls were successfully trained in domestic sciences, and millions of young Germans genuinely idolized Hitler. When the Second World War broke out, this generation of youth conformed and fought with unmatched fanaticism, proving that the years of school and Hitler Youth drilling had succeeded in shaping the minds of millions of young Germans.

In conclusion, while the regime did succeed in maintaining high levels of outward conformity through compulsory laws and school indoctrination (as argued in Interpretation 1), I largely agree with Interpretation 2. The success was superficial; by attempting to control every hour of a teenager's life with rigid military drilling, the Nazis triggered widespread boredom, massive absenteeism, and a vibrant youth counter-culture that proved the limits of totalitarian indoctrination by 1939.

Enquiry: The success of Nazi youth policies in the years 1933–39

3(a) How useful are Sources B and C for an enquiry into the success of Nazi youth policies in the years 1933–39? Explain your answer, using Sources B and C and your knowledge of the historical context. (8)

3(b) Study Interpretations 1 and 2. They give different views about the success of Nazi youth policies in the years 1933–39. What is the main difference between these views? Explain your answer, using details from both interpretations. (4)

3(c) Suggest one reason why Interpretations 1 and 2 give different views about the success of Nazi youth policies in the years 1933–39. You may use Sources B and C to help explain your answer. (4)

3(d) How far do you agree with Interpretation 2 about the success of Nazi youth policies in the years 1933–39? Explain your answer, using both interpretations and your knowledge of the historical context. (16+4 SPaG)

Turn over ▶